

Semi Pelagianism Denial

doc-semi-pelagianism-denial

Soteriology · Denied Errors · doctrine · divided_lineages

AFFIRMS

score 0.950
confidence medium

Statement under examination

The sinner does not take the first step toward God by natural ability with grace then assisting; rather, the prior gracious work of God enables any movement of the will toward Him.

In plain language

The Greek of these verses keeps putting God's action before the person's first move toward him. In John 6:44 and 6:65 the words say no one is able, dynatai, to come unless, ean me, the Father first draws, helkyo, or has given, a perfect form marking a settled earlier gift. The same verb for draw is used elsewhere for hauling a net and dragging people to court, so it is a real pull, not just an offer. John 15:16 flips the order plainly, you did not choose me but I chose you. First John 4:19 says we love because he first, protos, loved us. In Acts 16:14 the Lord opened, dianoigo, Lydia's heart so that she paid attention, the opening coming before the attending. Romans 9:16 says it does not depend on the one who wills but on God who shows mercy, and Philippians 2:13 says God is the one working in believers even the willing itself. Taken together these priority words say the first step is God's, which is exactly the point in question, because semi-Pelagianism is the claim that the person makes the first move by natural ability and grace only helps afterward. The words push against that. There is still a narrower and separate question the vocabulary does not settle. Once grace has gone first, does that prior work by itself fully produce the willing, or does it enable a will that then genuinely and freely consents. Careful readers divide here, and both sides agree the divine act comes first. They differ only on how complete that prior work is. Because the verbs clearly make the initiating act God's, the evidence affirms that grace must begin the movement, while the completeness of that prior work stays open, so confidence is medium rather than high.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0025	ἀγαπῶμεν	agapaō	to love	
G0846	αὐτὸς	autos	it/s/he	
G1223	διὰ	dia	through/because of	
G1272	διανοίγω	dianoigo	to open up	9
G1325	δίδωμι	didomi	to give	428
G1410	δύναμαι	dynamai	be able	211
G1435	δῶρον	doron	gift	19
G1473	ἐγὼ	egō	I/we	
G1537	ἐκ	ek	out from	
G1586	ἐκλέγομαι	eklegomai	to select	22
G1653	ἐλεέω	eleeo	to have mercy	32

G1670	ἐλκύω	helkyo	to draw/persuade	8
G1754	ἐνεργέω	energeo	be active	21
G2041	ἔργων	ergon	work	
G2064	ἐλθεῖν	erchomai	to come/go	
G2107	εὐδοκία	eudokia	goodwill	9
G2309	θέλω	thelo	to will/desire	214
G2316	θεοῦ	theos	God	
G2443	ἵνα	hina	in order that/to	
G2588	καρδίαν	kardia	heart	
G2744	καυχῆσθαι	kauchaomai	to boast	
G2962	κύριος	kurios	lord	
G3756	οὐ	ou	no	
G3962	πατήρ	patēr	father	
G4337	προσέχειν	prosechō	to watch out	
G4771	ὁμεῖς	su	you	

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

On the narrow initiation question the cited Greek consistently puts the divine act before the human movement toward God. John 6:44 and 6:65 join the negated potential verb dynatai to the condition ean me, so coming is impossible unless the Father first draws (helkyse, aorist subjunctive) or has given (dedomenon, perfect passive). Rom 9:16 negates ou tou thelontos, the one willing, with the adversative alla relocating the ground to tou eleontos theou, and Phil 2:13 names God as energon even to thelein, the willing itself. John 15:16 reverses the order, ouch hymeis exelexasthe all ego exelexamen, and 1 John 4:19 marks God protos, first. Acts 16:14 has the Lord dienoixen the heart so as to prosechein, the opening preceding the attending. These priority markers foreclose the semi-Pelagian claim that the human takes the unaided first step. The distinct and narrower cooperation question, whether the prior work fully effects the willing or enables a will that still freely consents, is not ranked by the vocabulary, hence medium confidence.

Scripture

John.6.44 · **for** · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1410 δύναται, G1670 ἐλκύση, G2064 ἐλθεῖν, G3962 πατήρ

Force. The negated potential verb dynatai joined to the condition ean me makes coming impossible apart from a prior act of the Father. That act is helkyse, the aorist active subjunctive of helkyo, draw or drag. Across its eight canon occurrences helkyo names a forceful effectual drawing, dragging Paul and Silas to the marketplace in Acts 16:19, dragging from the temple in Acts 21:30, drawing a sword in John 18:10, hauling the net in John 21:6 and 21:11, so the verb here describes an initiating divine pull, not a mere offer, and the coming follows it rather than precedes it.

John.6.65 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1410 δύναται, G1325 δεδομένον, G1537 ἐκ, G3962 πατρός

Force. The same negated dynatai plus ean me construction grounds the ability to come in the perfect passive participle dedomenon, it has been given, ek tou patros, from the Father. This verse uses didomi rather than helkyo, and the perfect tense marks a settled prior gift as the standing precondition of the human approach, again placing the divine act first.

Rom.9.16 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2309 θέλοντος, G1653 ἐλεώντος, G3756 οὐ, G2316 θεοῦ

Force. The clause negates ou tou thelontos, the one willing, and oude tou trechontos, the one running, then with the strong adversative alla locates the determining ground in tou eleontos theou, the God who shows mercy. Human willing, the very faculty the semi-Pelagian first step would exercise, is expressly displaced as the operative cause and the merciful God is named instead.

Phil.2.13 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2316 θεός, G1754 ἐνεργῶν, G2309 θέλειν, G2107 εὐδοκίας

Force. The causal gar grounds the preceding exhortation in God who is energon, the present active participle of energeo, working in believers both to thelein, the willing, and to energein, the working, for his eudokia, good pleasure. Including the infinitive to thelein within God's operation places the gracious work prior to and beneath the act of the will itself, which is the precise point the proposition asserts.

John.15.16 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1586 ἐξελέξασθε, G1586 ἐξελεξάμην, G1473 ἐγώ, G4771 ὑμεῖς

Force. The verse reverses the order of initiative directly, ouch hymeis me exelexasthe, you did not choose me, all ego exelexamen hymas, but I chose you. Both verbs are eklegomai in the aorist middle, and the negation of the human subject paired with the emphatic ego makes the divine choosing the prior and operative act, with the human relation following from it rather than originating it.

1John.4.19 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0025 ἀγαπῶμεν, G0025 ἠγάπησεν, G0846 αὐτός

Force. The clause hemeis agapomen, we love, is grounded in hoti autos protos egapesen hemas, because he first loved us. The adverbial protos, first, makes God's love explicitly prior in order to the human love, so the human response is presented as derivative of and consequent upon a divine act that precedes it.

Acts.16.14 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G1272 διήνοιξεν, G2588 καρδίαν, G4337 προσέχειν, G2962 κύριος

Force. The narrative states that ho kyrios dienoixen ten kardian, the Lord opened the heart, of Lydia, with the infinitive prosechein, to attend, expressing the result. The verb dianoiigo occurs nine times in the canon and consistently names a supernatural opening done to a recipient, opening eyes, Scriptures, minds and ears in Luke 24:31, 24:32, 24:45 and Mark 7:34. The divine opening precedes and produces the attending, so the human attention is consequent on the prior divine act.

Eph.2.8 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1435 δῶρον, G2316 θεοῦ, G1537 ἐξ, G1223 διὰ

Force. Salvation is by grace through faith, and the demonstrative touto is qualified as ouk ex hymon, not from yourselves, but theou doron, the gift of God. The framing sets the gift over against human origination, consistent with grace preceding the human response rather than assisting an autonomous first move.

Eph.2.9 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2041 ἐργων, G3756 οὐκ, G2744 καυχήσεται, G2443 ἵνα

Force. The phrase *ouk ex ergon* excludes works as the source, and the *hina* clause states the purpose that no one may boast, *kauchesetai*. Removing all ground of boasting in the human contribution reinforces that the initiative does not originate in the human will, though this verse addresses the source of salvation broadly rather than the will-grace ordering specifically.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
John.6.44	John.12.32	tsk	1
John.6.44	John.6.65	tsk	1
John.6.44	John.6.45	tsk	1
Acts.16.14	John.6.44	tsk	1
Acts.16.14	Rom.9.16	tsk	1
1John.4.19	John.15.16	tsk	1
Phil.2.13	2Chr.30.12	tsk	1
Rom.9.16	Rom.9.11	tsk	1

Complicating texts

John.12.32 · addressed

The cross reference for John 6:44 uses the same verb *helkyo*, *kago ean hypsotho ek tes ges pantas helkyso pros emauton*, I will draw all to myself. Some read *pantas*, all, as universalizing the drawing so that it no longer functions as a discriminating prior cause. That reading bears on the extent of the drawing, not on its priority. Lexically *helkyo* still names a divine act that precedes coming, so the proposition about grace initiating the movement is sustained regardless of how the scope of *pantas* is resolved.

Rom.9.11 · addressed

The cross reference grounds Romans 9:16 in election *me ek ergon*, not from works, before the twins had done anything good or bad. This strengthens rather than complicates the priority reading, since it removes prior human action as the basis. The lexical force of *ou tou thelontos* in 9:16 is consistent with it.

Phil.2.12 · addressed

The immediately preceding verse commands *katargazesthe*, work out your own salvation, which on a cooperative reading keeps a real human acting alongside the divine working of 2:13. This does not complicate the priority claim, since the *gar* of 2:13 grounds the human working in God who first *energei* the willing. The human activity is presented as flowing from the prior divine operation, not as an unaided first step, so the ordering the proposition asserts holds while leaving the cooperation question open.

Concordance traversed

G1670, G1410, G1754, G2309, G1653, G1325, G1586, G1272, G1435, G2107, G2064, G3962, G2041, G2744

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

None of the cited verses fall within the ingested ECM window of 3 John, so no apparatus units were examined here. The marked readings on the bundle surface forms, for example the bracketed *me* in John 6:44 and the *patros* note in John 6:65, touch the surrounding words but not the lexemes *dynatai*, *helkyse*, *dedomenon*, *energon*, *thelontos*, *exelexamen*, *protos* or *dienoixen* that carry

the verdict, so the reading is treated as variant robust.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. monergism, synergism

analogia scripturae invoked

grace-initiates reading: affirms · Reads the priority markers as decisive against the semi-Pelagian first step. The negated dynatai plus ean me in John 6:44 and 6:65, ou tou thelontos in Romans 9:16, energon to thelein in Philippians 2:13, the reversed eklegomai in John 15:16, the protos of 1 John 4:19 and the dienoixen that produces prosechein in Acts 16:14 all locate the initiating act in God. On this lens the human cannot supply the first movement toward God by natural ability, because every cited construction places a divine act prior to and as the enabling ground of that movement.

synergistic cooperation reading: partially affirms · Grants the same priority that the texts assert, since helkyo, didomi, energeo, eklegomai and dianoigo each name a real prior divine initiative, so this lens also denies the bare semi-Pelagian first step. It then distinguishes a narrower question the vocabulary does not settle, whether the prior grace fully effects the willing or enables a will that still freely and non-coercively consents. On this reading prevenient grace goes first and is necessary, yet a genuine human assent remains within the response, so the priority is affirmed while the completeness of the prior work is held open.

Both lenses agree that the cited lexemes place a divine act before the human coming and therefore both reject the semi-Pelagian unaided first step. They diverge only on the narrower and distinct question of whether that prior work fully effects the willing or enables a will that still consents. The shared lexical floor, which is what this proposition asserts, is that grace initiates the movement. The contested point lies beyond the proposition, in the completeness of that prior work, which the words do not rank.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Examine whether the sinner can take the first step toward God by natural ability with grace then assisting, or whether a prior gracious work of God must enable any movement of the will toward Him.

The stem encodes its own conclusion in the clause rather, the prior gracious work of God enables any movement of the will toward Him, which loads the answer before the evidence is weighed. The verdict was derived on the neutralized form, which poses the ordering as an open question. On the lexical merits the priority markers place the initiating act in God, which forecloses the specific semi-Pelagian first step. The narrower cooperation question, whether the prior work fully effects the willing, is not ranked by the vocabulary, which is reflected in medium confidence and the competing lens block.

Citations

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morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	John.6.44
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Phil.2.13
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	John.15.16
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Acts.16.14
interlinear	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	G1670
interlinear	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	G1272
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1754
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	John.6.44
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License audit

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